

A Word on Open Houses

Hopefully, you've been tempted enough to start hitting up open houses in your desired neighborhoods. If you haven't, now is the time to start. These are scheduled periods of time when a home for sale is open for viewing by potential buyers, and they're the perfect opportunity to scope out homes.

Before you get too excited, though, keep in mind that open houses don't actually exist to sell the house. Sure, that's a by-product of the open house, but the main purpose is so the agent can generate more buyer leads. Open houses lead to the actual sale of the home about 4 percent of the time.

When you're there, don't be afraid to say you're working with an agent. In fact, you *want* to let the open house agent know this. If you make an offer on a property, you want your agent to write that offer, protect your interests, and get paid. (Remember, if you sign an exclusivity agreement with the agent, you are agreeing that they will receive a portion of the purchase price as a commission.)

VIEWING TIPS

Ask your agent to print out listing sheets for each property. Bring your list of must-haves, nice-to-haves, and deal breakers and a pen so you can take notes on any house you are interested in. Jot down the things that stand out in each home to help you remember the property. It may sound crazy, but the homes really do tend to blur together.

If you walk through the house and are getting good vibes, go back to the front door and start looking for things to dislike. While this sounds counterintuitive, it helps you focus on things you may have overlooked in your initial pass because of that fabulous fireplace or those amazing floors.

Keep in mind not just your own preferences but also what a future buyer or potential renter might notice. If you buy this house and try to sell it five years down the road, what could be a turn-off to others? If you decide to turn this property into a rental, what would a tenant really hate to see? If you've walked through the house with a skeptical eye and find no deal breakers, now's the time to pull out your must-have list and look around one more time. Selling a house is expensive, and you definitely don't want